

DIGITAL Literacy

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PART A:

Case Study:

Understanding UPI & Online Payment Fraud

As digital payments become our everyday reality, understanding cybercrime is no longer optional—it's essential for protecting yourself in our connected world.



What Is UPI Fraud?



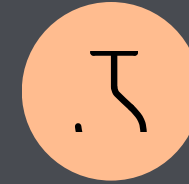
Instant Digital Theft

Unauthorized access to your Unified Payments Interface (UPI) or online banking credentials, resulting in immediate money transfer to fraudster accounts.



Impersonation Scams

Criminals pose as bank officials, customer service representatives, or trusted organizations to trick you into revealing sensitive information.



Phishing Attacks

Malicious links and QR codes disguised as legitimate requests that install malware or redirect to fake banking websites.

Why Students Are Prime Targets



Digital Natives, Security Novices

While students are comfortable with technology, they often lack practical cybersecurity knowledge and experience recognizing sophisticated scams.

Limited Financial Resources

Even small amounts matter—fraudsters know students may not have substantial savings, making every rupee stolen more impactful.

Trust-Based Behavior

Young adults tend to trust authority figures and official-sounding communications without sufficient verification.

The Fraud Process: Step-by-Step



Initial Contact

Receive a call or message claiming to be from your bank, e-commerce platform, or government agency. They create urgency about "suspicious activity" or "account verification."



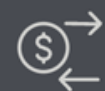
Phishing Link/QR Code

You're sent a malicious link or QR code to "secure your account" or "verify your identity." This captures your credentials or installs spyware.



Request for Access

They ask for your One-Time Password (OTP), UPI PIN, or banking credentials under the guise of "completing verification" or "resolving the issue."



Money Gone

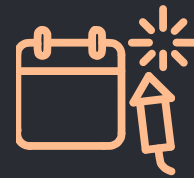
Within seconds, funds are transferred from your account to the fraudster's account. By the time you realize, it's often too late.

Who Gets Targeted Most?



College Students

Aged 18-23, actively using digital payments for food, transportation, and entertainment. Often share devices or accounts with family.



New Internet Users

First-time smartphone or banking app users who lack experience with online security practices and threat recognition.



Security-Unaware Individuals

People who haven't received cybersecurity education, don't understand phishing concepts, or are unfamiliar with bank protocols.

Devastating Consequences

Financial Loss

Immediate theft of money that may represent weeks of savings or essential funds for education and living expenses.

Emotional Distress

Anxiety, panic, shame, and fear about financial security. Many victims experience sleeplessness and constant worry about further attacks.

Identity & Data Misuse

Stolen credentials can lead to further fraud, unauthorized credit applications, and long-term damage to credit scores and financial reputation.



A Real Student's Experience

Case: Priya, 20-Year-Old University Student

Priya received a call claiming her UPI was compromised. The "bank officer" sounded professional and urgent. She was instructed to download an app to "secure" her account.

Within minutes, she received an OTP. Trusting the caller, she shared it. **₹15,000 vanished instantly** from her account. The number became unreachable. Priya spent weeks filing police reports and bank complaints, but recovery proved nearly impossible.

Lesson: Banks will NEVER call asking for your OTP or PIN. Always verify through official channels.

Protect Yourself: Essential Tips

01

Never Share OTP/PIN

Your One-Time Password and UPI PIN are YOURS only. No legitimate institution will ever ask for them.

02

Verify Independently

Hang up and call the official bank number directly to confirm any "urgent" claims about your account.

03

Don't Click Random Links

Avoid clicking links in unsolicited messages. Always access banking apps through official downloads or direct typing.

04

Check QR Codes Carefully

Scan only QR codes from trusted sources. Fraudulent codes can redirect to malicious payment requests.

05

Enable Transaction Limits

Set daily transaction limits on your UPI apps and enable notifications for every transaction.

06

Use App Lock Features

Enable biometric or PIN protection on your banking apps to prevent unauthorized access if your phone is lost.

What to Do If You're Targeted

Act Immediately

Every second counts. Don't panic—take systematic action.

- **Block Your Card**

Call your bank immediately to block the affected card or account.

- **File Complaint**

Report to cybercrime authorities at cybercrime.gov.in or local police.

- **Change Passwords**

Update all banking and UPI app credentials immediately.

- **Monitor Activity**

Watch for further unauthorized transactions and report them.

Stay Safe in the Digital Age

Knowledge Is Power

Understanding fraud methods makes you less vulnerable. Share this awareness with friends and family.

Trust Your Instincts

If something feels wrong, it probably is. Take time to verify before sharing any sensitive information.

Stay Updated

Follow official bank and government advisories about emerging scam techniques and prevention methods.

Remember: No legitimate bank or authority will ever ask for your OTP, PIN, or full password. Your vigilance is your best protection.

